Hiking Safety Guide

Essential safety for hiking in Pierce County from day hikes to backcountry scrambles

Pierce County offers some of the most spectacular hiking in the Pacific Northwest — from lowland forest trails to alpine routes on Mt. Rainier. But this terrain demands respect. As the SAR unit that responds when things go wrong, here's what we want every hiker to know before hitting the trail.

PIERCE COUNTY HIKING BY THE NUMBERS

1,800 square miles of terrain. Sea level to 14,411 ft. Trails range from paved waterfront paths to Class 3 scrambles on glaciated volcanic terrain. Weather can change from sunny to whiteout in under an hour. Most of our SAR calls involve hikers.

Know Your Terrain

Mt. Rainier National Park

The crown jewel of Pierce County and the most glaciated peak in the lower 48. Popular trails include Skyline, Wonderland, Tolmie Peak, and Spray Falls. Conditions change dramatically with elevation — the Paradise parking lot at 5,400 ft can be 30 degrees colder than the Nisqually entrance at 2,000 ft. Snow can linger on trails into July and return by October.

SAR PRO TIP

Check the NPS trail conditions page (nps.gov/mora) before every visit. Trails that were clear last weekend can be snow-covered or washed out this weekend. The Ranger stations at Longmire and Paradise have the most current info.

Carbon River & Mowich Areas

The northwest corner of Mt. Rainier National Park. Known for old-growth temperate rainforest, the Carbon Glacier (lowest-elevation glacier in the lower 48), and the remote Mowich Lake area. Trail bridges can wash out during fall/winter storms. Always check current access — road closures are common.

Cascade Foothills

The foothills between Buckley, Orting, and Eatonville offer moderate trails through second-growth forest. Popular with families and trail runners. Lower elevation means longer hiking season, but these areas can flood during heavy rain events.

Pierce County Hiking Hazards

Weather

Pacific Northwest mountain weather is notoriously unpredictable. Clear mornings can become afternoon thunderstorms. Fog can reduce visibility to near zero on ridgelines. Hypothermia is possible in any month — summer hikers in cotton are among our most common rescues.

- ☐ Check forecast for BOTH the trailhead and summit elevations
- ☐ Pack rain gear and insulating layers regardless of the forecast
- ☐ Set a turnaround time and honor it — afternoon weather is often worse
- ☐ Lightning: if you hear thunder, descend from ridges and exposed areas immediately

Lahars (Volcanic Mudflows)

Mt. Rainier is an active stratovolcano. While eruptions provide warning, lahars — fast-moving mudflows of rock, ice, and debris — can race down river valleys with little to no warning, reaching speeds of 40-50 mph. The Carbon, Puyallup, Nisqually, and White River valleys are all lahar paths.

LAHAR WARNING

If you hear a roaring sound and feel the ground shaking near a river valley, move UPHILL immediately — perpendicular to the valley, not downstream. Do not stop to look. Lahars can be 30+ feet deep and move faster than you can run. This is not a drill scenario — it's a real risk in Pierce County.

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Wildlife

Black bears, cougars, and elk all live in Pierce County's backcountry. Encounters are rare but happen. Make noise on the trail, carry bear spray above treeline, store food properly, and never approach or feed wildlife. Give wildlife at least 100 yards.

River Crossings

Glacial-fed rivers in Pierce County can rise dramatically in the afternoon as snowmelt increases. What was a knee-deep crossing in the morning can be waist-deep and dangerous by afternoon. Unbuckle your pack's hip belt before crossing so you can shed it if you fall. Use trekking poles for stability. Cross at the widest, shallowest point.

Hiking Preparation Checklist

- ☐ Ten Essentials: Every trip, no exceptions. See our Ten Essentials Guide.
- ☐ Trail research: Check conditions, snow level, recent trip reports (WTA, AllTrails).
- ☐ Navigation: Offline maps downloaded + physical topo map + compass.
- ☐ Trip plan: Filed with emergency contact. Include route, vehicle, return time.
- ☐ Footwear: Sturdy boots with ankle support for anything above lowland trails.
- ☐ Traction: Microspikes for spring/fall trails with snow. Ice axe for alpine routes.
- ☐ Water: Carry 2-3L. Treat all backcountry water sources (giardia is common).
- ☐ Start early: Hit the trail by 7-8 AM. Afternoon weather is worse, and you want daylight margin.
- ☐ Permits: Discover Pass for state land. NP entry fee for Rainier. Wilderness permits for overnight.

SAR PRO TIP

The most common mistake we see: hikers who planned a 'short day hike' but didn't bring enough water, warm layers, or a headlamp. A twisted ankle at mile 3 turns a 2-hour hike into an overnight if you're not prepared. Pack for the worst case, not the best.

Recommended Apps for Hiking

AllTrails+ ($36/yr): Best for trail discovery, reviews, offline maps. Gaia GPS ($40/yr): Best for serious navigation with topo layers. Used by SAR teams. Organic Maps (free): Great backup with offline trail data.

SATELLITE 911 TEXTING

T-Mobile offers satellite 911 texting — FREE for all carriers (emergency 911 only). Full satellite messaging is $10/mo. Works on 60+ phone models (iPhone 13+, Galaxy S21+). Sign up at t-mobile.com/coverage/satellite-phone-service/911-texting-signup